

HERE AND NOW AI

Artificial Intelligence Research Institute

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INTERNAL POLICY DOCUMENT

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION & COMPANY OVERVIEW

1.1 About HERE AND NOW AI

HERE AND NOW AI – Artificial Intelligence Research Institute is a Chennai-based organisation founded in 2018 and dedicated to making artificial intelligence accessible to every learner and organisation. Operating at the intersection of AI research, technology development, and immersive education, the Institute delivers enterprise-grade AI solutions, practical AI training programmes, and pioneering research initiatives directed towards the development of autonomous AI systems, including the flagship Robo-Professor (Probot) project.

The company operates across two primary verticals: (i) HERE AND NOW AI – Artificial Intelligence Research Institute, focused on research, product development, and enterprise AI services; and (ii) HERE AND NOW – The Language Institute, providing world-class French, English, and German language education augmented by adaptive AI platforms.

1.2 Purpose of this Policy Document

This Internal Policy Document (hereafter the 'Policy' or 'Document') establishes the standards, expectations, procedures, and guidelines governing all activities conducted by employees, contractors, interns, and associates of HERE AND NOW AI. It is designed to:

- Ensure consistent, ethical, and legally compliant conduct across all functions.
- Protect the company's intellectual property, data assets, and reputation.
- Safeguard the wellbeing, rights, and dignity of every member of the team.
- Provide clear guidance on research, technology development, and client service delivery.
- Establish transparent processes for performance management, grievance resolution, and policy review.

1.3 Scope & Applicability

This Policy applies to all individuals who work for, or on behalf of, HERE AND NOW AI in any capacity – whether full-time, part-time, contractual, or intern – and regardless of geographic location. All such individuals are referred to collectively as 'team members' throughout this document.

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CHAPTER 2

MISSION, VISION & CORE VALUES

2.1 Vision Statement

To pioneer a future in which advanced AI agents – culminating in a fully autonomous Robot Professor – transform learning, enterprise workflows, and global innovation. By harnessing cutting-edge frameworks and protocols, HERE AND NOW AI aims to democratise AI, foster intelligent collaboration, and enable lifelong, autonomous learning across communities and industries worldwide.

2.2 Mission Statement

- **Democratise AI education** through accessible, expert-led programmes founded in theory and enriched with hands-on practice.
- **Drive seamless AI integration** within businesses and institutions via enterprise-grade AI-as-a-Service (AlaaS) solutions.
- **Advance research** in deep learning, reinforcement learning, and autonomous agent frameworks to push the boundaries of AI.
- **Build ethical AI** systems that are transparent, accountable, and aligned with human values and societal benefit.
- **Cultivate an inclusive AI ecosystem** that empowers learners, professionals, and organisations regardless of background.

2.3 Core Values

Value	Definition
Innovation	We relentlessly explore new ideas, technologies, and methodologies to remain at the frontier of AI.
Integrity	We conduct all activities with transparency, honesty, and ethical responsibility.
Excellence	We hold ourselves to the highest standards in research, teaching, and service delivery.
Accessibility	We believe AI and quality education should be available to all, and we design our products accordingly.
Collaboration	We build through teamwork – across disciplines, cultures, and geographies.
Accountability	We own our actions, decisions, and results, and we learn openly from our mistakes.
Student-Centricity	Every decision, product, and policy is evaluated through the lens of learner and client benefit.

CHAPTER 3

ORGANISATIONAL STRUCTURE & LEADERSHIP RESPONSIBILITIES

3.1 Organisational Overview

HERE AND NOW AI maintains a lean, innovation-driven structure with clearly defined leadership roles and responsibilities. The founding leadership team brings complementary expertise spanning AI/ML science, technology engineering, language education, and business operations.

3.2 Leadership Profiles & Responsibilities

3.2.1 Ruthran RAGHAVAN — Chief AI Scientist

Ruthran Raghavan is the Chief AI Scientist of HERE AND NOW AI. With a background in cognitive science (M.Sc. Psychology, Madras University) and over a decade of experience in AI/ML research, he is the principal architect of the organisation's AI strategy and research agenda.

Key Responsibilities:

- Setting the overall strategic vision, mission, and long-term direction of the organisation.
- Overseeing all AI research initiatives including Probot (Professor Robot), RAG systems, and predictive ML models.
- Leading the design and deployment of deep learning models (CNNs, GANs, RNNs, LSTMs) for educational applications.
- Directing AI model fine-tuning, prompt engineering, and reinforcement learning with human feedback (RLHF).
- Ensuring the ethical development and deployment of all AI systems.
- Building and maintaining key partnerships with academic institutions, corporations, and research bodies.
- Representing the organisation in public forums, conferences, and media.
- Final signatory authority on all major policies, contracts, and strategic documents.

Core Technical Competencies: PyTorch, TensorFlow, Keras, Scikit-Learn, Hugging Face, GPT-4, Llama 3.1, Mistral, LangChain, RAG systems, OpenAI GPT/ada embeddings, Docker, Kubernetes, AWS SageMaker, Python.

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3.2.2 Deepti BALAGOPAL — COO, Language Scientist & Director

Deepti Balagopal serves as Chief Operating Officer and Language Scientist at HERE AND NOW AI, and as Director & Curriculum Designer at HERE AND NOW – The Language Institute. A distinguished multilingual educator (French C1, English C2, Tamil C1, Malayalam C2, Hindi B2), she has been instrumental in driving 300% student enrollment growth and scaling the institute into a nationally recognised leader in language education.

Key Responsibilities:

- Overseeing day-to-day operations across both the AI research institute and the language institute.
- Designing and implementing AI-enhanced language teaching methodologies and curricula.
- Managing curriculum development for IB, IGCSE, CBSE, and State Board schools.
- Leading business development initiatives, marketing strategy, and client relationship management.
- Directing translation, interpretation, voice-over, and subtitling projects.
- Managing the full language department – recruitment, payroll, training, and quality assurance.
- Training 1,000+ French educators in AI-augmented teaching tools.

- Spearheading programmes such as the IMMERSION PROGRAM (A1–B2 in 108 days) and TEF COMPASS.
- Overseeing content creation, proofreading, and brand communications.

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3.2.3 Balaji KAMALAKKANNAN — Chief Technology Officer (CTO)

Balaji Kamalakkannan is the Chief Technology Officer of HERE AND NOW AI (from January 2025) and has served concurrently as CTO of Hexagon Computers since 2011. He is a highly experienced technology architect with deep expertise in full-stack development, Generative AI, immersive technologies (AR/VR), and enterprise cloud infrastructure.

Key Responsibilities:

- Architecting and deploying enterprise-scale Generative AI platforms integrating RAG, vector search (FAISS, ChromaDB, Pinecone), and multi-agent orchestration with LangGraph.
- Overseeing development of 200+ AI-powered applications and 100+ intelligent agents for automation, analytics, and decision support.
- Managing cloud infrastructure across AWS, Azure, GCP, and self-hosted environments.
- Introducing and maintaining GitHub Copilot in development pipelines to accelerate delivery by up to 10x.
- Leading AI training programmes and bootcamps for universities and corporate teams.
- Directing AR/VR learning and simulation tool development using Unity, WebGL, ARKit, and ARCore.
- Delivering cross-platform mobile AI applications using Flutter.
- Setting and enforcing technology standards, cybersecurity practices, and DevOps processes.
- Overseeing IoT integrations, full-stack architecture, and API ecosystem design.

Core Technical Competencies: PyTorch, TensorFlow, LangChain, LangGraph, FAISS, ChromaDB, Pinecone, Python, JavaScript, ReactJS, VueJS, AngularJS, C#, .NET, Flutter, AWS, Azure, GCP, Docker, Kubernetes, Unity3D, Three.js, WebGL.

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CHAPTER 4

CODE OF CONDUCT & PROFESSIONAL ETHICS

4.1 Purpose

The Code of Conduct defines the ethical standards expected of all team members in their professional activities. It reflects the core values of HERE AND NOW AI and ensures that all interactions – internal and external – are conducted with integrity, respect, and professionalism.

4.2 General Conduct Standards

- Act with honesty and transparency in all professional dealings.
- Treat all colleagues, students, clients, and partners with courtesy, dignity, and respect.
- Avoid conflicts of interest; disclose any actual or potential conflicts promptly to the Chief AI Scientist.
- Protect confidential information of the organisation, its clients, and partners at all times.
- Refrain from any form of harassment, discrimination, bullying, or intimidatory behaviour.
- Comply with all applicable Indian laws, regulations, and international standards.
- Use company resources – including AI tools, computing infrastructure, and data – solely for authorised purposes.
- Report any known or suspected breach of this Code promptly to the appropriate authority.

4.3 Ethical AI Development Standards

Given the nature of our work in artificial intelligence, all team members engaged in AI research, development, and deployment must additionally adhere to the following principles:

Principle	Requirement
Transparency	AI models, their training data, and their limitations must be documented and disclosed to relevant stakeholders.
Fairness	All AI systems must be designed to minimise bias and promote equitable outcomes across demographic groups.
Privacy by Design	Personal data must be processed only with appropriate consent and safeguards. Privacy considerations must be embedded from the design stage.
Human Oversight	No AI system shall be deployed in a manner that removes appropriate human oversight or accountability, particularly in high-stakes decisions.
Accountability	Every AI project must have a named responsible person accountable for its outcomes.
Non-Maleficence	No AI tool, model, or system developed by HERE AND NOW AI shall be used to deceive, harm, or exploit individuals.

4.4 Gifts & Anti-Corruption

Team members shall not offer, accept, or solicit gifts, hospitality, or any benefit that could influence or appear to influence professional decisions. Token gifts of nominal value (below INR 1,000) for cultural or celebratory purposes are permissible but must be declared. Any payment, gift, or benefit offered with the intention of

obtaining business advantage constitutes bribery and will result in immediate disciplinary action.

4.5 Social Media & Public Statements

Team members must not make public statements – on social media, in the press, or at public events – that could be construed as official positions of HERE AND NOW AI without prior written approval from the Chief AI Scientist or COO. Personal opinions shared publicly must be clearly identified as personal and not representative of the organisation. Refer to Chapter 14 for the full Social Media Policy.

CHAPTER 5

EMPLOYMENT POLICIES

5.1 Recruitment & Selection

HERE AND NOW AI is committed to recruiting the most capable and suitable individuals for every role. All recruitment shall be based on merit, skills, and organisational fit. The following principles govern our hiring process:

- All open positions shall be advertised through appropriate channels, including the company website, LinkedIn, and relevant job platforms.
- Selection criteria shall be defined before the process begins and applied consistently to all candidates.
- Interview panels shall include at least two team members, and decisions shall be made collectively.
- Background verification, including reference checks, shall be conducted before issuing formal offers.
- Offers of employment shall be made in writing, clearly stating role, compensation, and start date.
- All new team members must complete orientation and onboarding within the first two weeks of joining.

5.2 Types of Engagement

Type	Description	Notice Period
Full-Time Employee	Standard employment with full benefits and responsibilities.	30 days
Part-Time Employee	Agreed fixed hours per week with proportional benefits.	14 days
Contractor / Consultant	Project-based engagement under a service agreement.	Per contract terms
Intern / Trainee	Fixed-term learning engagement, typically 1–6 months.	7 days
Research Associate	Academic or research-focused role, often on a stipend.	14 days

5.3 Working Hours & Flexibility

The standard working week is 40 hours, typically Monday to Friday, 09:00–18:00 IST, with a one-hour lunch break. Given the research and technology nature of our work, flexible arrangements including remote work, compressed weeks, and asynchronous schedules may be agreed upon with the relevant department head. Any agreed flexible arrangement must be documented in writing.

5.4 Leave Policy

Leave Type	Entitlement	Conditions
Annual / Earned Leave	18 days per year	Accrues monthly; minimum 7 days to be taken continuously.
Sick Leave	12 days per year	Medical certificate required for 3+ consecutive days.
Casual Leave	6 days per year	For unforeseen personal needs; max 2 days at a time.
Maternity Leave	26 weeks (as per law)	Per Maternity Benefit Act, 1961 (as amended).
Paternity Leave	5 working days	Within 3 months of child's birth/adoption.
Public Holidays	As per Tamil Nadu govt. calendar	Minimum 10 days per year, announced in January.

Bereavement Leave	3 days	For immediate family member; additional days unpaid.
Study / Exam Leave	Up to 5 days per year	For approved professional development; requires documentation.

5.5 Compensation & Benefits

Compensation packages are determined based on role, experience, market benchmarks, and individual performance. Salaries are reviewed annually. Benefits may include, subject to eligibility:

- Provident Fund (PF) and Employee State Insurance (ESI) contributions as per applicable law.
- Performance-linked bonuses, reviewed semi-annually.
- Access to all HERE AND NOW AI training programmes and courses at no cost.
- Professional development budget (up to INR 20,000 per year for eligible team members).
- Health & wellness support, including access to mental health resources.
- Certification and conference attendance support, subject to business needs.

CHAPTER 6

AI RESEARCH & DEVELOPMENT POLICY

6.1 Research Governance

All AI research and development activities at HERE AND NOW AI must be conducted in accordance with this policy, ethical AI principles (Chapter 4), and applicable laws. The Chief AI Scientist holds ultimate authority over the research agenda and has oversight responsibility for all R&D; outputs.

6.2 Active Research Projects & Innovation Portfolio

Project	Description	Lead
Probot – Professor Robot	An AI-powered autonomous educational assistant for French, German, and English language learning. Utilises advanced NLP models and TTS modules. Currently in active development.	Chief AI Scientist
Predictive Enrollment ML Model	Random Forest, GBM, and LSTM-based model predicting student enrollment patterns, improving accuracy by 20% and reducing marketing costs.	Chief AI Scientist
Predictive Success ML Model	Forecasts student course completion with 25% improvement in completion rates.	Chief AI Scientist
Automated Evaluation System	Deep learning (CNN, GAN, RNN) system for real-time grading of open-ended responses with ±3% accuracy vs. human evaluators.	Chief AI Scientist
RAG Systems	Retrieval-Augmented Generation systems for adaptive content delivery and administrative efficiency.	CTO & Chief AI Scientist
Conversational AI Systems	Multilingual chatbots and voice-bots using GPT, Mistral, Llama 3.1 with RLHF; 40% improvement in vocabulary retention.	Chief AI Scientist
Autonomous AI Professor Framework	Multimodal teaching agent with adaptive learning using LLMs, LangChain, and RAG pipelines.	CTO
Multi-Agent Enterprise Automation	Parallel and looping agent frameworks for large-scale operational task automation.	CTO
OCR Systems for Education	CNN-based OCR digitising handwritten materials; 85% reduction in manual data entry.	Chief AI Scientist
GenAI Financial Chatbots	Natural language interfaces for financial decision-making.	CTO
AR/VR Simulation Toolkit	Immersive training tools built with Unity and WebGL.	CTO

6.3 Research Process Standards

- All new research projects must be formally proposed, documented, and approved by the Chief AI Scientist before commencement.
- Research documentation (methodology, datasets, results, model versions) must be maintained in the organisation's version control system (GitHub).
- Model training must be conducted on approved infrastructure only; unauthorised use of personal devices or third-party compute without security approval is prohibited.
- All datasets used in research must comply with the Data Governance Policy (Chapter 7).
- Research findings intended for external publication must undergo internal review and receive Chief AI Scientist approval prior to submission.
- Open-source contributions are encouraged but require review to ensure no proprietary IP is inadvertently disclosed.

6.4 Technology Stack Standards

The following technology standards apply to all development activities:

Category	Approved Technologies
AI/ML Frameworks	PyTorch, TensorFlow, Keras, Scikit-Learn, Hugging Face Transformers, LangChain, LangGraph, OpenCV
LLMs & GenAI	GPT-4, Llama 3.1, Mistral, DALL-E, OpenAI ada embeddings, open-source LLMs via Hugging Face
Vector Databases	FAISS, ChromaDB, Pinecone, Elasticsearch
Programming Languages	Python (primary for AI/ML), JavaScript/TypeScript, C#, PHP, Java, Dart (Flutter)
Web Frameworks	ReactJS, VueJS, AngularJS, Node.js, FastAPI, Svelte
Cloud & DevOps	AWS SageMaker, Azure, GCP, Docker, Kubernetes, Jenkins, Terraform, GitHub Actions
Databases	MS SQL, MySQL, MongoDB, PostgreSQL
Immersive Tech	Unity3D, Three.js, WebGL, ARKit, ARCore
Chatbot Platforms	DialogFlow, RASA (for legacy systems)

CHAPTER 7

DATA GOVERNANCE & PRIVACY POLICY

7.1 Governing Framework

HERE AND NOW AI processes personal and organisational data in connection with its educational programmes, AI research, and enterprise services. All data handling must comply with the Information Technology Act, 2000 and the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 (DPDPA) of India, and where applicable, the EU General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) for international data subjects.

7.2 Data Classification

Classification	Description	Examples
Public	Information approved for external release.	Website content, published research, course brochures.
Internal	For internal use only; not for external sharing without approval.	Internal communications, meeting notes, project plans.
Confidential	Sensitive business or personal data requiring restricted access.	Employee records, student data, client contracts, financial data.
Restricted	Highest protection level; access strictly limited.	AI model weights (proprietary), source code, encryption keys, board decisions.

7.3 Data Processing Principles

- **Lawfulness:** Personal data is processed only on a valid legal basis (consent, contract, legitimate interest, or legal obligation).
- **Purpose Limitation:** Data is collected for specified, explicit purposes and not further processed in incompatible ways.
- **Data Minimisation:** Only data strictly necessary for the stated purpose is collected.
- **Accuracy:** Data is kept accurate and up to date; inaccuracies are corrected promptly.
- **Storage Limitation:** Data is retained only as long as necessary; refer to the Retention Schedule maintained by the CTO.
- **Security:** Technical and organisational measures are in place to protect data against unauthorised access, loss, or destruction.
- **Accountability:** The Chief AI Scientist bears ultimate accountability for data protection compliance; the CTO is responsible for technical safeguards.

7.4 Research Data Handling

Training datasets used in AI model development may include student performance data, language learning outputs, and engagement metrics. All such data must be anonymised or pseudonymised before use in model training. Consent must be obtained where identifiable data is used. Synthetic data generation is preferred for model testing and validation phases.

CHAPTER 8

INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY & CONFIDENTIALITY POLICY

8.1 Ownership of IP

All intellectual property created by team members in the course of their employment or engagement with HERE AND NOW AI – including but not limited to AI models, source code, algorithms, datasets, curricula, training materials, research papers, and product designs – is the exclusive property of HERE AND NOW AI, unless an alternative arrangement is expressly agreed in writing.

8.2 Proprietary Assets

- AI model architectures, weights, and training pipelines developed internally.
- The Probot (Professor Robot) system and all associated NLP/TTS modules.
- RAG system architectures and knowledge bases.
- Predictive enrollment and student success ML models.
- Automated evaluation system (CNNs, GANs, RNNs).
- IMMERSION PROGRAM, TEF COMPASS, Sprint Program curricula and pedagogical methods.
- Adaptive learning platform algorithms.
- All client-specific AI tools developed under service agreements.
- Training programme materials, course content, and assessments.

8.3 Confidentiality Obligations

All team members must sign a Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA) prior to or on their first day of engagement. Confidentiality obligations survive the termination of employment for a period of three (3) years. Team members shall not:

- Disclose any confidential information to third parties without written authorisation.
- Use proprietary information for personal benefit or for the benefit of a competitor.
- Remove proprietary materials (physical or digital) from company systems without authorisation.
- Discuss client details, business strategies, or research findings in public settings.

CHAPTER 9

INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY & CYBERSECURITY POLICY

9.1 IT Governance

The CTO (Balaji Kamalakkannan) is responsible for all technology infrastructure, cybersecurity architecture, and IT governance. All IT systems, cloud infrastructure, and AI deployment environments are managed under the CTO's authority.

9.2 Acceptable Use of IT Resources

- Company IT resources (hardware, software, cloud accounts, AI APIs) are provided for business use only.
- Personal use of company devices is permitted in moderation but must not compromise security, performance, or productivity.
- Team members must not install unauthorised software on company devices.
- Access credentials (passwords, API keys, tokens) must never be shared and must be stored securely using approved password managers.
- Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is mandatory for all critical systems including cloud platforms, GitHub, and administrative tools.
- Team members must lock their devices when leaving them unattended.

9.3 AI API & Model Usage

Given the organisation's intensive use of AI APIs (OpenAI, Hugging Face, etc.), the following additional controls apply:

- API keys must be stored in environment variables or approved secrets management tools, never hard-coded in source code.
- Costs associated with AI API usage must be monitored and reported to the CTO monthly.
- Prompt injection risks in deployed AI systems must be assessed and mitigated.
- Model outputs should not be presented as human-generated without appropriate disclosure.
- All LLM deployments must undergo security review before production release.

9.4 Cybersecurity Standards

The organisation follows cybersecurity best practices aligned with ISO/IEC 27001 principles, including but not limited to:

- Regular vulnerability assessments of web applications, APIs, and cloud infrastructure.
- Encrypted data transmission (TLS 1.2+) for all client-facing and internal services.
- Encrypted storage for all sensitive data.
- Automated security scanning integrated into CI/CD pipelines (GitHub Actions).
- Incident response plan maintained by the CTO; all security incidents must be reported within 24 hours.
- Regular security awareness training for all team members.
- Backup and disaster recovery procedures tested quarterly.

CHAPTER 10

TRAINING, EDUCATION & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT POLICY

10.1 Commitment to Continuous Learning

HERE AND NOW AI places professional development at the heart of its culture. As an organisation whose primary business is education and AI advancement, all team members are expected to maintain and continuously improve their technical and professional skills.

10.2 Internal Training Programmes

Team members have full access to all HERE AND NOW AI courses and workshops, including:

- Intensive AI Programme (Full Stack AI)
- RAG & Fine-Tuning LLMs Workshop
- Building AI Chatbots with LangChain
- Computer Vision with YOLO & OpenCV
- Speech Recognition & Voice AI
- Reinforcement Learning for AI Agents
- AI-Powered Code Generation & Debugging
- AI in Cybersecurity: Threat Detection & Prevention
- Natural Language Processing (NLP) with Python
- French Language Programmes (IMMERSION PROGRAM, TEF COMPASS, Sprint Program)

10.3 External Development

Team members may apply for funding to attend external conferences, obtain professional certifications, or pursue advanced academic studies. Applications must be submitted to the COO at least 30 days in advance and are subject to budget availability. Where external training is company-funded, a minimum 12-month continued service commitment applies.

10.4 Knowledge Sharing

Team members are encouraged to share knowledge through internal lunch-and-learn sessions, documentation of research findings, and contribution to the company's knowledge base. The CTO maintains the internal technical wiki; the COO oversees the pedagogical knowledge repository.

CHAPTER 11

CLIENT & STAKEHOLDER RELATIONS POLICY

11.1 Client Service Standards

HERE AND NOW AI serves a diverse client base including individual learners, corporate clients (such as Saint-Gobain), educational institutions (Saveetha Group, Tagore Group), Canadian immigration aspirants, and enterprise AI clients. All client interactions must reflect the organisation's values of excellence, responsiveness, and integrity.

- All client communications must be professional, timely, and accurate.
- Client data and contractual terms are strictly confidential.
- Service agreements must be reviewed by the Chief AI Scientist or COO before signing.
- Client complaints must be acknowledged within 24 hours and resolved within 5 business days.
- Client satisfaction must be measured through regular feedback mechanisms.

11.2 Partner Relations

Strategic partnerships with academic institutions, government bodies, and technology partners must be formally documented. All partnerships involving IP sharing, data sharing, or joint research require Chief AI Scientist approval and legal review.

CHAPTER 12

HEALTH, SAFETY & WELLBEING POLICY

12.1 Physical Safety

HERE AND NOW AI is committed to providing a safe working environment, whether in-office or remote. All team members must:

- Report any hazardous conditions, accidents, or near-misses to management immediately.
- Follow all health and safety guidelines applicable to the work environment.
- Ensure their remote workspace meets basic ergonomic and safety standards.

12.2 Mental Health & Wellbeing

Recognising the high-intensity nature of AI research and technology development, the organisation is committed to supporting the mental health of all team members. This includes fostering a culture where team members feel safe to discuss workload concerns, providing access to mental health resources, and ensuring managers are trained in identifying and addressing signs of burnout or distress. Excessive overtime is actively discouraged; sustainable performance is prioritised.

CHAPTER 13

FINANCIAL & PROCUREMENT POLICY

13.1 Financial Authority & Controls

Expenditure Level	Approval Authority
Up to INR 5,000	Any team member (with receipt)
INR 5,001 – INR 25,000	Department Head
INR 25,001 – INR 1,00,000	COO
INR 1,00,001 – INR 5,00,000	Chief AI Scientist
Above INR 5,00,000	Chief AI Scientist + Board / Founding Team Approval

13.2 Procurement Standards

- Procurement of AI tools, software licences, cloud services, and hardware must be evaluated for technical fit, cost-effectiveness, and security compliance.
- Vendor due diligence must be conducted for all technology partners with access to organisational data.
- Expense claims must be submitted with supporting receipts within 7 days of incurrence.
- All contracts and service agreements must be reviewed by the Chief AI Scientist before execution.
- AI API usage costs (OpenAI, cloud platforms) are monitored by the CTO and reported monthly.

CHAPTER 14

COMMUNICATION & SOCIAL MEDIA POLICY

14.1 Internal Communication Standards

Primary internal communication tools include Slack (team collaboration), email, and scheduled meetings via video conferencing platforms. Team members are expected to respond to internal communications within one business day. Communication must remain professional, respectful, and constructive at all times.

14.2 External & Social Media

- Official company communications on social media platforms (LinkedIn, Instagram, Twitter/X, YouTube) are managed by the COO with oversight from the Chief AI Scientist.
- Team members are encouraged to engage positively with company content and promote their professional work, while clearly distinguishing personal from official views.
- No confidential business information, client details, unreleased product information, or proprietary research may be shared on any social media platform.
- Team members must not make statements about competitors, clients, or colleagues on social media that could damage the company's reputation.
- Negative or inflammatory comments about the organisation, its leadership, products, or clients on social media constitute a disciplinary matter.
- Content promoting the company's AI courses, products, or research must be factually accurate and approved by the COO.

CHAPTER 15

DIVERSITY, EQUITY & INCLUSION POLICY

15.1 Our Commitment

HERE AND NOW AI celebrates diversity in all its forms and is committed to creating an inclusive environment where every individual – regardless of gender, age, religion, caste, nationality, language, disability, sexual orientation, or socioeconomic background – is valued, respected, and given equal opportunity to contribute and grow. Our multilingual team, spanning expertise in French, English, Tamil, Hindi, Malayalam, and German, embodies this commitment.

15.2 Non-Discrimination

Discrimination of any kind in recruitment, promotion, assignment, compensation, training, or any other employment practice is strictly prohibited. Any team member who engages in discriminatory behaviour or who facilitates discrimination by others will be subject to disciplinary action up to and including termination.

15.3 Inclusive AI Development

Diversity and inclusion extend to our AI development work. All AI systems must be designed to function equitably across user demographics. Bias testing is a mandatory step in the model evaluation pipeline for any AI system that interacts with or makes decisions about individuals.

CHAPTER 16

PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT POLICY

16.1 Performance Framework

Performance management at HERE AND NOW AI is continuous, constructive, and aligned to both individual growth and organisational objectives. The framework includes:

Touchpoint	Frequency	Purpose
Check-In	Weekly / Bi-weekly	Operational updates, blocker resolution, wellbeing check.
Performance Review	Semi-annual (April & October)	Structured review of OKRs, competencies, and career development.
Annual Appraisal	Annual (March)	Comprehensive assessment; compensation and promotion decisions.
360-Degree Feedback	Annual	Peer, subordinate, and leadership feedback for holistic evaluation.
Project Reviews	Upon project milestone/completion	Technical and delivery quality assessment for AI/tech projects.

CHAPTER 17

GRIEVANCE & DISCIPLINARY PROCEDURE

17.1 Grievance Policy

HERE AND NOW AI encourages open dialogue. Any team member with a workplace concern or grievance is encouraged to raise it promptly. The grievance procedure is as follows:

- Step 1: Raise the concern informally with your direct manager or the COO.
- Step 2: If unresolved within 5 working days, submit a formal written grievance to the Chief AI Scientist.
- Step 3: The Chief AI Scientist shall investigate the matter and provide a written response within 10 working days.
- Step 4: If the team member is dissatisfied with the outcome, an appeal may be submitted to a neutral review panel within 5 days of receiving the response.
- Step 5: All grievances are handled confidentially and without retaliation.

17.2 Disciplinary Procedure

Disciplinary action is reserved for breaches of policy, misconduct, or sustained performance issues. The following graduated process applies (except in cases of gross misconduct):

- **Verbal Warning:** Informal discussion noting the concern and expected improvement.
- **Written Warning:** Formal documentation of the concern, expectations, and timeframe for improvement.
- **Final Written Warning:** Issued if no improvement following the written warning.
- **Suspension / Termination:** For serious, repeated, or gross misconduct.

Gross misconduct (including data breach, IP theft, fraud, harassment, or serious breach of AI ethics) may result in immediate suspension and termination without prior warning.

CHAPTER 18

ENVIRONMENTAL & SUSTAINABILITY POLICY

18.1 Our Environmental Commitment

HERE AND NOW AI acknowledges the significant energy demands of AI compute workloads and is committed to minimising its environmental footprint. Measures include:

- Preferring cloud providers with demonstrable renewable energy commitments (AWS, Azure, GCP all publish sustainability reports).
- Optimising model training efficiency to reduce unnecessary compute – smaller, more efficient models are preferred where performance requirements are met.
- Minimising paper use through digital-first documentation practices.
- Encouraging sustainable commuting and supporting remote work to reduce travel emissions.
- Measuring and reporting on the organisation's carbon footprint annually from 2026.

CHAPTER 19

POLICY REVIEW & GOVERNANCE

19.1 Review Cycle

This Policy Document shall be reviewed annually, or sooner in the event of significant changes to applicable law, business structure, or operational practice. The review is led by the Chief AI Scientist with input from the COO and CTO.

19.2 Amendments

Amendments to this policy must be approved by the Chief AI Scientist. Material changes will be communicated to all team members within 5 business days of approval. Team members are required to acknowledge receipt and understanding of any updated policy.

19.3 Policy Hierarchy

Where a conflict exists between this document and any specific departmental policy or procedure, this document takes precedence unless a specific exception has been approved in writing by the Chief AI Scientist. In all cases, applicable law takes precedence over internal policy.

CHAPTER 20

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT & SIGN-OFF

20.1 Team Member Acknowledgement

All team members are required to read this policy document in full and sign the acknowledgement below upon commencement of their engagement and whenever a material update is issued. Signed copies must be submitted to the COO's office within 5 business days of receipt.

Full Name	Role / Position	Date	Signature

20.2 Executive Approval

Prepared By	Reviewed By	Approved By
Ruthran RAGHAVAN Chief AI Scientist hereandnow.co.in	Deepti BALAGOPAL COO & Director hereandnow.co.in	Ruthran RAGHAVAN Chief AI Scientist – HERE AND NOW AI April 29, 2025
Signature: _____	Signature: _____	Signature: _____
Date: _____	Date: _____	Date: _____

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